



I put \$30,000 of private money into strengthening BC's local food system.

The result?

I was told to park the truck for 14 weeks.

My name is Liam Milovick. I'm the Co-Founder of Local Connect Foodservice, and I think our experience exposes a much bigger problem with how we approach food sovereignty in this province.

A few months ago, LC was still in its early stages. We were doing a few thousand dollars a month with a handful of restaurants and working to prove there was real demand for what we were building.

Since then, alongside my incredible investors Khalid and Jamal, we have grown LC into a food distribution company moving over 10,000 lbs of food every month.

And these pounds aren't just the same products coming off a traditional distributor's truck. It's chicken from Colonial Farms in Armstrong, bread from Specialty Bakery in Kelowna, and produce from Stoney Flats in Pritchard, to name a few.

These are BC food businesses, and our job is pretty simple: get their food into more restaurants.

Then, the day after Canada Day, I'm driving through Kelowna when the transmission in our refrigerated Chevy Express, lovingly known as "Ol' Clunky," decides it has had enough.

We had a decision to make. We could dump thousands of dollars into fixing an aging van, or we could recognize that LC had outgrown it and invest in proper equipment.

So we invested roughly \$30,000 of our own money into an Isuzu NRR refrigerated truck. No government assistance, no grant, no funding program. Just a 22 year old entrepreneur and hospitality investors putting our own money behind strengthening BC product driven foodservice distribution.

To me, this was exactly what everyone says they want to see. A small business grows, creates demand for local products, outgrows its equipment, reinvests and buys proper commercial equipment so it can keep growing.

Except our reward for doing that was being told to park the truck.

By moving from a light duty Chevy Express into a commercial spec truck, we crossed the 5,000 kg threshold that triggers BC's National Safety Code carrier requirements.

I want to be very clear about something. I have no problem with the NSC requirement. Commercial trucks should be safe. Carriers should be accountable. Drivers should be qualified. Equipment should be maintained properly.

That isn't the problem.

The problem is being told the application takes roughly 14 weeks to process.

Fourteen. Entire. Weeks.

Think about that from the perspective of a small business. You identify a bottleneck, take the financial risk, invest \$30,000 of your own capital to solve it and buy the proper equipment.

Then you park that equipment for more than three months while the paperwork gets processed.

That is what frustrates me when I hear enormous funding numbers thrown around in conversations about strengthening our food system. We love announcing billions for agriculture, food security, infrastructure and economic development.

And yes, funding matters. But you can pour billions into a sector and still make it incredibly difficult for the businesses inside that sector to succeed.

Lab2Market Validate taught me one incredibly important lesson. If you want to understand a market, stop assuming you know what the problems are and actually talk to the people operating in it.

So I did.

I talked to producers, food hubs, manufacturers, restaurants and logistics operators. Different businesses with different challenges, but one issue kept showing up: red tape getting in the way of growth.

Food sovereignty is about more than growing food. Someone has to process it, store it, sell it and ultimately put it on a truck and get it where it needs to go. If those businesses can't grow, neither can our local food system.

That's the disconnect.

We found the customers, built the supplier relationships, built the infrastructure, took the financial risk and bought the truck.

We didn't ask the government to buy it for us.

We asked for permission to operate it.

And now it sits.

I don't want a handout or fewer safety standards. I want to invest our own money, follow the rules and get to work without losing a quarter of a year waiting for paperwork.

A stronger local food system won't be measured by how many billions we announce. It will be measured by how much local food actually makes it from BC producers onto BC plates.

We're trying to do exactly that.

CVSE, fix the process so we can get back to fixing the food system.

@Peter Milobar, @Mike Farnworth, help me get to work.